GENDERED INSECURITY AND GENDERED RELATIONS AT THE STATE LEVEL

A feminist analysis of socio-economic relations reveals a link between gender inequality and gender insecurity. This is because inequality in accessing power, justice, and resources provides the conditions that enable the use of gender-based violence (Davies and True 2015). For example, recent research has shown a significant correlation between the systematic occurrence of sexual violence and the absence of laws relating to domestic violence; acceptance of domestic violence; and poor or limited access to public space, property, resources, and entitlements for women (Davies and True 2015, p. 10). In this way, women's inequality in accessing property, employment, and political decision-making provides an important strategic site for analysing the relationship between gendered insecurity and violence.

As will be elaborated in more detail below, Kachin women, often situated as single heads of households during conflict times, report lower levels of income compared to men in their community (see Table 4.3), and face serious barriers in accessing both public spaces and justice mechanisms. For example, in areas under KIO control, issues related to women's physical insecurity are often delegated to customary authorities or, if the matter involves KIA soldiers, are dealt with by a military court (Kamler 2015). Kachin women's groups maintain that neither of these authorities takes issues of sexual violence or domestic violence seriously enough. At the national level, women in Myanmar lack legal protection given the absence of laws penalizing domestic violence and marital rape (Gender Equality Network 2013a).[4] In addition, the current constitution includes a clause that effectively absolves the state military of any responsibility for crimes committed against women during conflict.[5] This culture of impunity heightens women's exposure to gender-based violence. The low level of women in public office arguably also exacerbates this, as women lack access to levers of legislative power. The violence that women experience in Kachin State is thus directly connected to their inequality in social and economic status, and the lack of legal avenues to address this. In other words, gender inequality ensures that the marginalization of women from public decision-making processes is maintained. This in turn contributes to exacerbating women's insecurity.